Module 3 · Workbook answers

Setting your goals

Video: 42 min **Answer sheet**

With your values and your true identity in place, this module sets the goal of life itself: to become a khalifah (representative of Allah) and a wali (friend of Allah) by reflecting His attributes. You will see why this world exists to reveal what is inside you, and how to start by closing the "open windows" in your body, mind and heart.

Answer sheet: the answers are in red. The reflection questions are personal, so your own answers will be in your own words and from your own life. These model answers show what the session teaches, to guide and check your thinking.

Key teachings

1. **Why the first two modules come first**

   Module 1 showed that reflecting Allah's attributes is the best value you can have, and Module 2 showed that your core identity is your spirit, carrying four trusts (amanah): the body, mind, heart and soul, which you will one day hand back. Roles like entrepreneur, employee, stay-at-home mum or career woman are not your core identity; a mum who invests decades in her children can feel lost when they leave home. Goals built on the wrong identity end in disappointment. The would-be millionaire buys course after course, does not become rich and feels a failure, while those who do become millionaires simply chase a billion, and many wealthy people admit their possessions never brought them happiness.

2. **The goal: to become a khalifah**

   The Qur'an announces our goal near its very beginning. Al-Fatihah praises the Lord of the worlds, the Most Merciful, and then asks for guidance. Al-Baqarah answers: this Book is that guidance. It then describes three kinds of people (the believers, the disbelievers and the hypocrites), and soon after comes the announcement to the angels that Allah will place a khalifah on earth. The speaker teaches that this role is unique to human beings: our task is to become living reflections of Allah's attributes, using the trusts He gave us, and to hand them back in the best state.

3. **The friend of Allah (wali)**

   Another word for this goal is wali, the friend of Allah. Friends are people who share things in common. The speaker once spent an hour talking about martial arts with a guest he had nothing in common with; the guest enjoyed it, but they never met again. In the same way, the friend of Allah is the one who truly reflects His attributes. It is not reserved for those who learn Arabic, perfect their tajwid (rules of Qur'an recitation), move to a Muslim country or attend expensive courses. Correct belief is necessary, but it is not the end of the story. Anyone can do this from home, in whatever circumstances they are in.

4. **Lead with love**

   Start the process with love, because Allah is Al-Wadud (the Most Loving). The speaker teaches that Allah created the universe out of love for His attributes, and that someone who loves something shares it, just as we teach a young child to share. We do not become part of Allah; we reflect His attributes. The goal is not to collect "brownie points" for Paradise and avoid "naughty points" for Hell: Paradise is the meeting place, and the real goal is Allah's pleasure. This love gives you the drive to act now, because we do not know when we will hand our trusts back; the speaker mentions two young women in their twenties and thirties who died suddenly.

5 **This world reveals what is inside you**

The purpose of this world is to reveal what is inside you. You already have good qualities (perhaps you are naturally truthful or merciful), but others only come out through life's tests. If someone defrauds you, you can forgive and reflect Al-Ghafur (the All-Forgiving), or hold a grudge. If a greedy person suddenly becomes wealthy, will they reflect Al-Karim (the Most Generous)? Iblis worshipped among the angels, yet his hidden arrogance came out when Adam was created. A saying attributed to Ali puts it simply: money and fame do not corrupt, they reveal. So do not ask "Why is this happening to me?" but "How am I responding?"

6 **The blindfolded climber**

Climbing a mountain is hard, yet people do it. Climb it blindfolded and you bump into things, hurt yourself, get hungry, and none of it makes sense. Take the blindfold off and the same climb makes sense and becomes enjoyable. Understanding that the world is there to reveal what is inside you is what takes the blindfold off. We are all born good (there is no original sin in Islam), but our tests will show which qualities need work.

7 **Close the windows before turning up the heating**

Imagine a cold room with the windows open: you keep turning up the heating, but the room never warms. Many people add good deeds (such as learning Arabic, which is good in itself) but feel nothing changes, because the windows are still open. First cease, then increase. A sin is something that goes against Allah's attributes, and it lets darkness into the heart, leaving people unfulfilled (the speaker is clear this is not about clinical conditions, which need professional help). Once the windows are closed, a little good is enough to warm the room, because our natural state is one of light. Close them one by one; you do not need to pray all night.

8 **Windows to close, organ by organ**

The tongue: stop lying (Allah is Al-Haqq, the Truth), exposing others' faults (He is As-Sittir, the One who conceals; in the story of Musa, Allah concealed a sinner for years and would not expose him on the day he repented), false promises (Allah keeps His promises) and cursing. Then use it well: kind words, remembering Allah, good advice, smiling, and silence. The eyes and ears: Allah is Al-Basir and As-Sami' (the All-Seeing, the All-Hearing), so avoid indecent images and empty talk; look at nature and listen to the Qur'an. Cover and keep the private parts clean, eat healthily, walk to the masjid, give charity, think well of others (as Allah thinks well of us), be grateful (Allah appreciates our efforts), and trust Ar-Razzaq (the Provider) instead of taking what is not yours.

From the Qur'an, the Sunnah and the scholars

وَإِذْ قَالَ رَبُّكَ لِلْمَلَٰٓئِكَةِ إِنِّى جَاعِلٌ فِى ٱلْأَرْضِ خَلِيفَةً ۖ قَالُوٓا۟ أَتَجْعَلُ فِيهَا مَن يُفْسِدُ فِيهَا وَيَسْفِكُ ٱلدِّمَآءَ وَنَحْنُ نُسَبِّحُ بِحَمْدِكَ وَنُقَدِّسُ لَكَ ۖ قَالَ إِنِّىٓ أَعْلَمُ مَا لَا تَعْلَمُونَ

And [mention], when your Lord said to the angels, "Indeed, I will make upon the earth a successive authority." They said, "Will You place upon it one who causes corruption therein and sheds blood, while we exalt You with praise and declare Your perfection?" He [Allah] said, "Indeed, I know that which you do not know."

Surah Al-Baqarah 2:30

يَٰبَنِيٓ إِسۡرَٰٓءِيلَ ٱذۡكُرُواْ نِعۡمَتِيَ ٱلَّتِيٓ أَنۡعَمۡتُ عَلَيۡكُمۡ وَأَوۡفُواْ بِعَهۡدِيٓ أُوفِ بِعَهۡدِكُمۡ وَإِيَّٰيَ فَٱرۡهَبُونِ

O Children of Israel, remember My favor which I have bestowed upon you and fulfill My covenant [upon you] that I will fulfill your covenant [from Me], and be afraid of [only] Me.

Surah Al-Baqarah 2:40

وَقَالَ ٱلَّذِينَ كَفَرُواْ لَا تَسۡمَعُواْ لِهَٰذَا ٱلۡقُرۡءَانِ وَٱلۡغَوۡاْ فِيهِ لَعَلَّكُمۡ تَغۡلِبُونَ

And those who disbelieve say, "Do not listen to this Qur'an and speak noisily during [the recitation of] it that perhaps you will overcome."

Surah Fussilat 41:26

إِنَّ هَٰذَا كَانَ لَكُمۡ جَزَآءٗ وَكَانَ سَعۡيُكُم مَّشۡكُورٗا

[And it will be said], "Indeed, this is for you a reward, and your effort has been appreciated."

Surah Al-Insan 76:22

> *Allah, Mighty and Majestic, is Forbearing, Modest and Concealing. He loves modesty and concealment, so when any of you bathes, let him cover himself.*
>
> **Sunan Abi Dawud**

> *There are two blessings in which many people lose out: health and free time.*
>
> **Sahih al-Bukhari**

Practical exercises

Is this goal worthy of me?

1. List three goals you have been chasing (for example money, a career, a house, a role).
2. For each, ask: does this rest on my core identity, my spirit, or on a passing role?
3. Ask: if I reached it, would it make me a better reflection of Allah's attributes?
4. Rewrite your main life goal in one sentence, starting "My goal is to become a friend of Allah by..."
5. Write your intention to lead with love: why do you want this?

How am I responding?

1. Think of a recent test: someone wronged you, a loss, or a sudden blessing.
2. Write what it revealed inside you, good or bad.
3. Name the attribute of Allah you could have reflected (for example Al-Ghafur, the All-Forgiving, or Al-Karim, the Most Generous).
4. Write how you would respond next time, so the blindfold is off.

A plan for every trust

1. Start with the tongue: tick which window is most open for you (lying, exposing others' faults, false promises or cursing), and write one step to close it.
2. Do the same for the eyes, ears, private parts, stomach, hands, feet, mind and heart (for example indecent images, empty talk, overeating, assuming the worst).
3. For each, write one good to increase (for example kind words, looking at nature, listening to the Qur'an, charity, walking to the masjid, gratitude).
4. Link each line to a name of Allah (for example Al-Haqq, As-Sittir, Al-Basir, As-Sami', Al-Karim, Ar-Razzaq).
5. Pick one to start with. Close one window at a time.

My week of closing windows

Tick each day you practise.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
No lying, cursing or exposing faults							
Guarded my eyes and ears							
Thought well of someone							
Thanked Allah for one blessing							

Reflection questions and answers

1. Which goal have you chased that, looking back, rested on a role rather than your true identity? How did it leave you feeling?

> Goals built on the wrong identity end in disappointment: the would-be millionaire who buys course after course and feels a failure, the mum who feels lost when her children leave home, and wealthy people who admit their possessions never brought them happiness. Roles are not your core identity; your spirit is. For example: "Buying a bigger house. I thought it would settle me, but once we moved I simply started wanting the next thing."

2. What does it mean to you that your goal is to be a khalifah and a friend of Allah, and that this is open to you whatever your circumstances?

> Our goal is to become a khalifah, a living reflection of Allah's attributes, and a wali (friend of Allah). Friends share things in common, so the friend of Allah is the one who truly reflects His attributes. This is not reserved for those who learn Arabic, perfect their tajwid or move to a Muslim country; anyone can do it from home. For example: "It gives me hope. As a busy parent I can still become a friend of Allah through how I treat my family."

3. Are your good deeds driven more by love for Allah, or by collecting points for Paradise? What would change if you led with love?

> The goal is not to collect "brownie points" for Paradise and avoid "naughty points" for Hell: Paradise is the meeting place, and the real goal is Allah's pleasure. Starting with love, because Allah is Al-Wadud (the Most Loving), also gives you the drive to act now, since we do not know when we will hand our trusts back. For example: "Mostly points, if I am honest. If I led with love, I think I would pray with more presence and stop counting what I have done."

4. Think of a hard test in your life. What did it reveal inside you, and how did you respond?

> This world exists to reveal what is inside you, just as Iblis's hidden arrogance came out when Adam was created; the saying attributed to Ali is that money and fame do not corrupt, they reveal. So the question is not "Why is this happening to me?" but "How am I responding?" For example: "When a friend cheated me out of money, it revealed a grudge I held for years. Next time I want to forgive and reflect Al-Ghafur, the All-Forgiving."

5. Which "open window" is letting the most cold into your heart right now?

> Like a cold room with the windows open, adding good deeds will not warm the heart while sins keep letting darkness in, so first cease, then increase. The session names windows such as lying, exposing others' faults, false promises, cursing, indecent images, empty talk and taking what is not yours. For example: "Exposing other people's faults when I chat with friends. Allah is As-Sittir, the One who conceals, so this is the window I will close first."

6. When someone annoys you (a driver, your spouse, your children), what good opinion could you hold of them instead?

> We are asked to think well of others, as Allah thinks well of us; assuming the worst is one of the open windows. A good answer imagines a fair reason for the other person's behaviour. For example: "When a driver cuts me up, I could think they may be rushing to someone who is ill. When my children are noisy, I could remember they are tired, not trying to upset me."

7. Which of Allah's names do you most want to reflect this week, and through which part of your body?

> The session links names of Allah to parts of the body: Al-Haqq (the Truth) and As-Sittir (the One who conceals) to the tongue, Al-Basir and As-Sami' (the All-Seeing, the All-Hearing) to the eyes and ears, Al-Karim (the Most Generous) to giving charity, and Ar-Razzaq (the Provider) to not taking what is not yours. For example: "Al-Haqq, through my tongue. This week I will not tell even small lies, including excuses at work."

My action plan

- [ ] I will make the intention to become a friend of Allah and a true khalifah.
- [ ] I will lead with love, seeking Allah's pleasure rather than points.
- [ ] When something happens to me, I will ask "How am I responding?" rather than "Why me?"
- [ ] I will close one window of the tongue this week before adding extra good deeds.
- [ ] I will think well of others, as Allah thinks well of us.
- [ ] I will write a plan for each of my trusts and bring it to the next session.